

The pros and cons of the 'social Web browser'

Let's have the pros first:

1. Tight integration with various social media networks like Orkut, Facebook, Twitter, Flickr, YouTube and many more.
2. 'My World' features an iGoogle-esque homepage that shows the latest updates on your social connections every time you start the browser.
3. Can be integrated so that you get notified of and can reply to new e-mails on GMail and Yahoo Mail, right on the browser.
4. Has the heart of Mozilla Firefox, the most used (and abused) open source browser that's fast, reliable, feature-rich and secure.
5. My personal experience says Flock leaks less memory than Mozilla Firefox.

And the cons:

1. Eats up a lot of screen real estate (the sole reason why I'd never use Flock, despite being a social media enthusiast myself).
2. The colour schemes are too bright to let you concentrate on the contents of the websites you might be visiting.
3. Not as many plug-ins are available for Flock as for Firefox.

news on Google reader or playing Scrabble on Yahoo Apps. All you need to do is stay logged into the Facebook network. What else? If you find something interesting while browsing the Web, all you need to do is drag the content and drop it on the side panel panel to share it with the world.

Speaking of drag-n-drop, Flock enables you to drag and drop content from any website on to the sidebar and share it with your contacts. To make life easier still, another new feature called FlockCast lets you automatically send an update to Facebook when you perform an action on another site. So, if you use the built-in



Figure 1: With the wider top bar, the side bar and the media browser, hardly any space remains for meaningful browsing

functions to add a post to your blog, upload a photo to Flickr, a video to YouTube or a status message to Twitter, you can get it instantly echoed on Facebook. Right now, only Facebook is supported as a destination, but it's a nice idea that could get much more useful if more services are supported in future Flock updates.

So, why isn't everyone around me using Flock?

Flock can, any day, be used as a normal Web browser—the way you might use Mozilla Firefox and Epiphany for your daily surfing needs. However, it becomes a little inconvenient, with less screen space allowed by Flock for browsing, unless you are one of those rich kids who can't think of anything below the 21-inch plasma monitors with super-high resolutions. The ugly and very bright sidebar, which is supposedly the strength and USP of the browser, actually makes browsing very cumbersome.

Moreover, while even Twitter can make you go bonkers with information overload, a complete browser with such heavy social functionalities built in, is definitely not meant for those with serious work to do, where one needs to remain focused. Even if you happen to be a social-media junkie, unless you have a lot of free time, you'll always



Figure 2: A Photo uploader built inherently within Flock

find yourself wanting to go back to whatever browser you are using.

Tip: There are a few Firefox plug-ins (like FireShot) that do work with Flock, but are not available for download. So, you can copy the Firefox's settings folder into that of Flock to get as many plug-ins as possible. However, in case some are not compatible, you will have to disable them yourself.

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